



Mortal Kombat

Kicking it old-school

Faiyaz Shaikh

readersletters@thinkdigit.com

As far as unfulfilled promises go, Mortal Kombat developers have been guilty on multiple counts ever since the series took the 3D root with its fourth installment. It was quite understandable given the context of those years when 3D graphics was a relatively new technology and almost all games were measured by its visual appeal. Throughout the years, the prevailing “wisdom” in the game’s industry appeared to be that if a game does not sport 3D graphics, then it’s not worth developing. Ed Boon and company struggled to find a balance between commercial pressures and the frustrated cries from fans of the original series. After multiple disappointments it seemed that the industry will perhaps never go back to the days of fast-paced 2D fighting games. This was until Capcom released Street Fighter IV and showed the community how to mix the best of both worlds into a game that can be commercially and critically successful. With a vision now

firmly in their minds, Netherrealm studio have set out to deliver a game which it arguably owes to the community.

Most of us are already horny enough about the game after watching game-play videos that have been doing the rounds for quite some time now. Unexpectedly however, we were invited by the game’s distributors for a hands-on experience at Warner Bros. office in south Mumbai. The build appeared to be a special press demo, which had a little more content than the game demo available to PSN+ subscribers. This demo had limited number of characters and only a couple of single-player modes available. Also, each of the characters had one fatality unlocked.

The training mode of the demo had a tutorial that walks the player through the basics of the game’s combat system. The game’s controls return to the classic scheme where each limb is mapped to the face-buttons. This makes moves like roundhouse kick, leg sweep and uppercut move identical for all fighters and it also leaves room to be creative with combos. Block has been mapped to a shoulder button, but running requires double-tap

of the directional key. The ‘Super’ meter is another direct inspiration from Street Fighter series, but it is also an extension of ‘Combo Breaker’ system that is native to the series. The Super meter can be used to break combos, super-charge special moves or execute the ‘X-ray’ move. The ‘X-Ray’ move looks humiliating enough and takes about quarter of the victims health, but it is certainly not a game-changer— unless, if it can be chained together with combos.

The controls are delightfully responsive even when using the analog stick on the Xbox 360 controller. This, combined with the overall combat scheme, makes chaining combos with special moves the heart of the game. The developers have made good use of the processing power they had to spare after restricting the combat to two dimensions. There is an impressive amount of detail on the character model and the animation is fluid and good to look at. The damage model, along with animated stage background makes for a pretty immersive experience. The overall art-style is a return to the dark and gruesome early days of the series. Also, we are happy to report that out of the few fatalities that we were able to pull-off during the demo, there was at least one that was cringe-inducing.

The new Mortal Kombat may or may not turn out to be the best fighting game ever; however, it is certainly shaping up to be the best game in the series after a long, long time. **d**